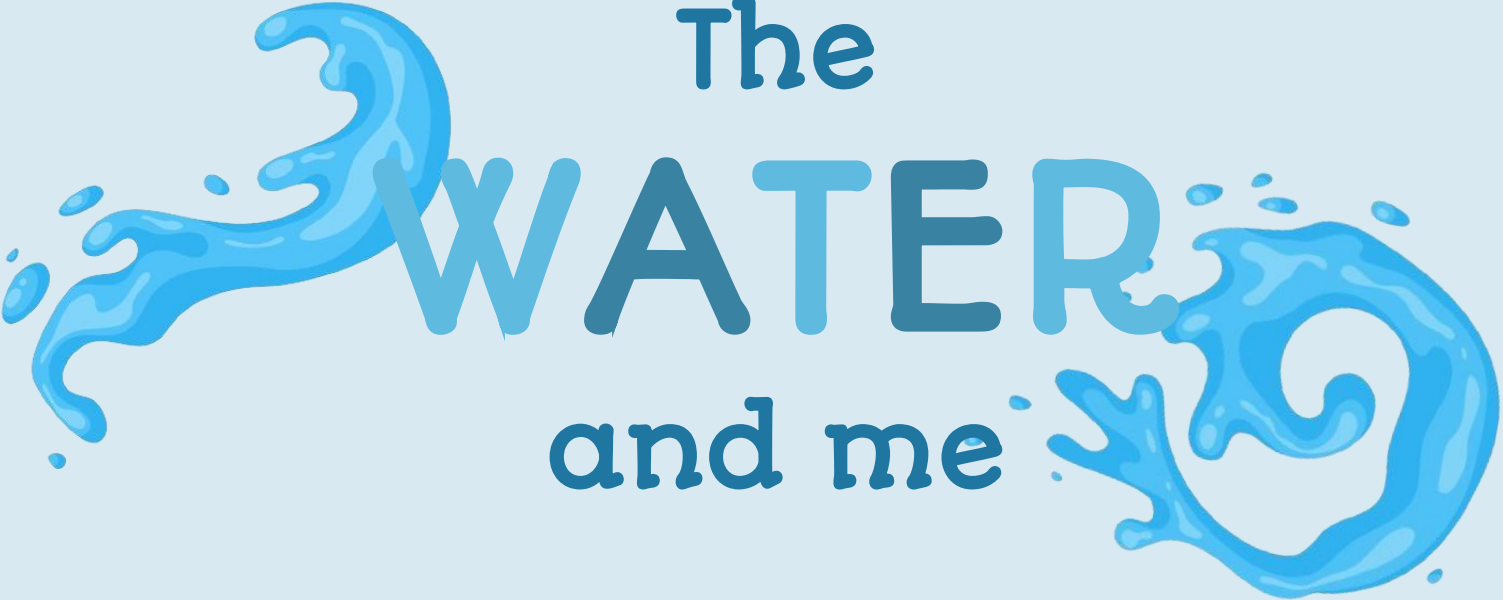


A stylized blue water splash graphic that frames the title text. The splash starts on the left, curves around the word 'WATER', and ends on the right, with several small droplets trailing off. The water is a vibrant blue with white highlights to suggest movement and reflection.

The WATER and me

A children's book by Camryn Evans



**Ever wonder why there
aren't many professional
swimmers that look like
you?**

**Or why when you go to the
beach, you don't see
many faces in the water
that look like yours?**



Before trying to answer why this might be the case, it's important to understand that difficulty swimming tends to affect the black community more than it affects others.



This difficulty has resulted in a higher rate of scary swimming accidents for black people.

Now you can probably see why there are only a few professional swimmers that are black, or why when you go to the beach, you don't see many black faces in the water — A higher chance of experiencing scary accidents urges many black folks to steer clear of the water.

But *why* does this unique difficulty swimming exist in the first place?

To help
answer this

question,

let's take a
look at the
different
perspectives
you might
encounter

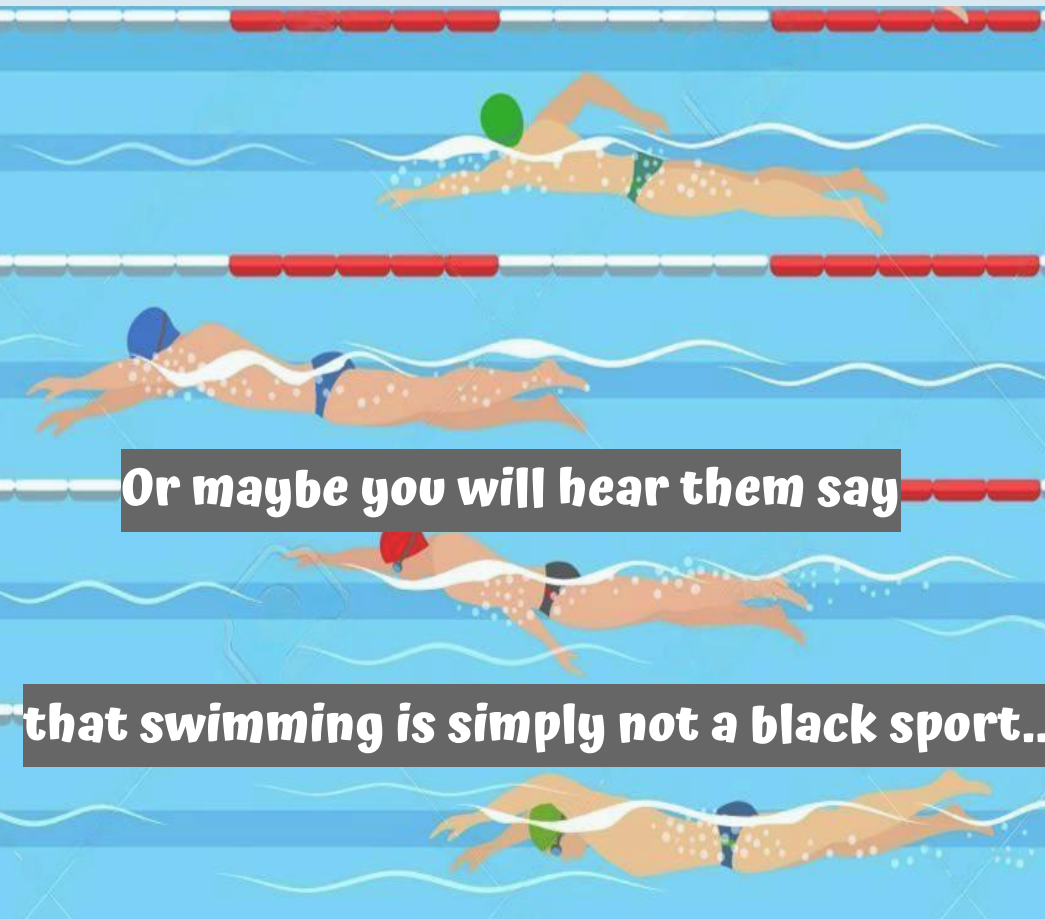
when talking

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**You might hear from your own
black friends and family that
they don't swim as much because
formal swimming lessons are
simply too expensive.**

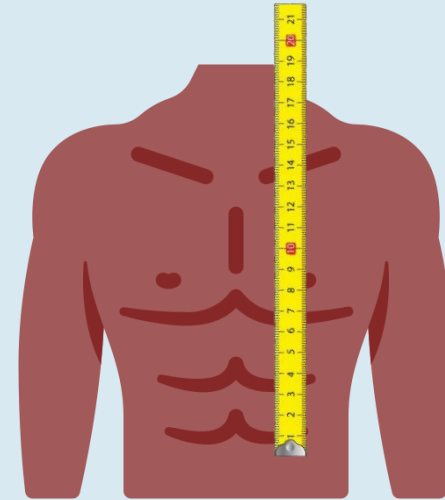


Or maybe you will hear them say

that swimming is simply not a black sport...

... and that there are already
so many *other* folks who
swim, and they don't feel at
home in a sport where they
are not comfortably
represented.

Others might claim that the lack of black folks in swimming is due to biological differences, such as a higher bone density which might make it harder for black individuals to float in the water...



...Or a slightly shorter torso which might result in slightly slower times in swim races.

Others might say that the lack of black folks in swimming isn't due to the expense of formal lessons, or to any biological differences, but instead to certain events from the past which have lasting effects impacts today.

They might mention how not too long ago in our country's history, swimming pools were segregated by race.



**And even when laws were finally
passed to change this unfair rule,**



**many black people were still
threatened and physically harassed
if they tried to swim in the same
pools as white people.**

**To avoid this scary harassment,
many black people stayed away
from the activity of swimming
altogether. As a result, they never
had a chance to properly learn to
swim, and so the practice and
knowledge of swimming couldn't
be passed on to their children, or
their children's children.**



You may have noticed by now that the perspectives we've discussed are all quite different from each other!

This can be tricky, because a historian who is studying the role of racist legacies in swimming might end up arguing with a biologist who is studying the role of physical differences in sports.



No matter what perspective is being offered, the most important thing to remember is that every individual is different;

Struggling in the water due to physical differences might really resonate with one black individual, while another might feel that the historical legacy of racism is the most significant roadblock for them when it comes to swimming.

It might even be the case that your own experience with swimming is completely different from the perspectives that we just explored in this book, and that's OK too!



**Again, every individual is
different, and while it's important
to be aware of the different
perspectives that exist out there,
it's equally important to
understand how those
perspectives resonate with *you*.**

THE END